General hints

1. Behaviour that is rewarded is more likely to be repeated than behaviour that is not rewarded.

Story: Emily's teacher gave her a smiley face on her chart each time that Emily used the toilet successfully – but ignored any accidents.

2. The reward chosen for the child with an ASD may be unusual, according to the individual child's interests. It may be appropriate to use as rewards objects, activities or special interests that are the chosen focus of the child's attention.

Story: Each time he completed his three work tasks, Alex was allowed to spend a few minutes playing with his collection of clocks.

3. The timing of the reward is important: the reward should follow the desired activity as quickly as possible, so that the child links the reward to the behaviour.

Story: Agneta was learning to share toys in the playground. Her support assistant carried a supply of sweets, so that Agneta could be rewarded immediately for any attempt to share.

4. New skills are learned more easily if broken down into small, easy steps. This helps the child understand what is required and avoid failure.

Story: Stefan was learning to get changed after PE. He was given a picture sequence of the items of clothing involved, in the appropriate order, so that he could see what to do.

5. For some (sequential) tasks it will be best to begin with the last step of the sequence, then teach the next to last step, and so on – until the child can complete the whole sequence independently. This process is called 'backward chaining'.

Story: At first, Stefan was physically prompted to put on all but the last item of clothing shown on his picture sequence, then left to put his shoes on unaided. Next, he was left to put on shoes and socks. Gradually he learned to do the whole sequence unaided.

6. In general, prompts can be used when the child is learning something new, but should then be faded.

Story: Charles was learning to use picture exchange, to request. At first, his teacher held a drink where he could see it, and held her hand out as a visual cue to receive the picture symbol. His support assistant stood behind Charles, waited for him to reach towards the drink, and then physically prompted him to put the picture symbol into his teacher's hand. At that point, his teacher said: 'Drink' and gave him the drink. Gradually, Charles learned to give the picture symbol without any prompting, so his support assistant left him to request a drink unaided.

7. When encouraging a new skill, or trying to change a behaviour pattern, it is best to ask the child to try for a brief time at first, and to stop before the child becomes bored or restless – thus avoiding a tantrum. The time can then be gradually extended.

Story: Danielle found it difficult to cope with attending assembly at school. She was helped by being introduced progressively to assembly, starting with the final five minutes and building up gradually until she could remain throughout. She was supported by a teaching assistant and rewarded for her co-operation by spending time with a favourite book after assembly.

8. All learning by the child will be helped if the adults involved plan what is to be learned, and how; use consistent strategies, language and rewards; and persevere, to give the child time to learn and to generalise learning.

Story: William had learnt to use the toilet at home in response to a picture symbol. The staff at his school tried to get William to use the toilet at school, but without success – until they asked his parents for a copy of the toilet symbol he used at home. When this became available to him at school, William began to use the toilet in both settings.